out and helped us to 260, exactly the score we had chased down in the quarter-final against Australia. It was a good total but not a clear winning score on a decent pitch.

In their reply, Pakistan also got off to a good start, but just as the pressure was starting to build on us, Zaheer struck. Munaf also got a wicket in the powerplay and then Yuvraj took two quick wickets to put us in control. In the middle of the innings, Umar Akmal was trying to counter-attack but we knew that all it would take was one good delivery. Harbhajan did the job for us by bowling Akmal with the first ball of his second spell. He had decided to come round the wicket and Akmal misjudged the line.

Pakistan still had a chance while Afridi and Misbah were batting, but then Afridi fell to Harbhajan, trying to hit a full toss out of the ground. He would normally have made that shot nine times out of ten but on that night he spooned a simple catch to cover. It was one of those days when things seemed destined to go our way. After dismissing Afridi, we knew we could close out the match. Soon enough Misbah holed out to Virat at long on and we were in the World Cup final. As if that wasn't enough, I also received the Player of the Match award, the third time I had that honour in a World Cup match against Pakistan.

The celebrations were quite something. We could see thousands of fans waving the tricolour and celebrating in Mohali. Navigating our way back to the hotel was a tricky business, with every corner taken over by delirious fans wanting to relish the moment. My friend Aamir Khan, the actor, came over to my room to offer his congratulations and I remember chatting away into the small hours. It was a night that India could never forget and we, having played a part in it, will never want to forget.

A number of dignitaries had come to Mohali, including our prime minister, Dr Manmohan Singh. The Pakistani premier, Yousaf Raza Gillani, was also present, but frankly we were not really taking in what was going on beyond the boundary because we were so preoccupied with the job at hand. We were soon on our way to Mumbai, convinced that we were peaking at the right time.

A city full of expectations

When we arrived in Mumbai for the final against Sri Lanka, the first thing I noticed was the increased police presence. It didn't feel like the